might even have been the product of a desire to uplift and educate, to promote the idea that Bangaloreans should not merely drink alcohol or write computer software, but also improve their minds. Perhaps she thought: let me get a group of writers to each recommend one book that ‘every Bangalorean *must* read’—and read collectively, around a table stacked with beer cans. In time they might even come to read books alone, in their rooms.

However, that the question was asked at all shows a depressing lack of familiarity with the most civilized pocket of what was once a very civilized city. So long as T.S. Shanbhag was around, and selling books, residents of Bangalore, whether journalists or otherwise, had no reason not to know of the works of John Steinbeck, and of other great writers past—such as Ivan Turgenev and Evelyn Waugh—or present—such as Milan Kundera and Ian McEwan—or home-grown—such as R.K. Narayan and Shivaram Karanth.

There was only one bookshop anywhere in India that matched Premier’s: that run by Ram Advani in the Hazratganj locality of Lucknow. That place too was adjacent to a library run by the British Council and down the road from a famous coffee house. The owner was a refugee from Sindh with a keen interest in golf and western classical music. He started his shop in the Lucknow of the 1940s, a very different place from the Lucknow of today. The city’s university was then first class; with superb sociologists, historians, literary scholars, and musicians. Sensing the city’s decline, the British Council closed down its library. The Hazratganj coffee house fell victim to a strike and a lockout. But Ram Advani is still there, pushing ninety, still attending to books and book buyers, the strains of Mozart in the background.

IV

After Achal Prabhala called with the news that Shanbhag was shutting shop, I went to Premier’s the next day, to find the owner almost as stoic as I had been told he would be. He rehearsed his reasons for retirement, but